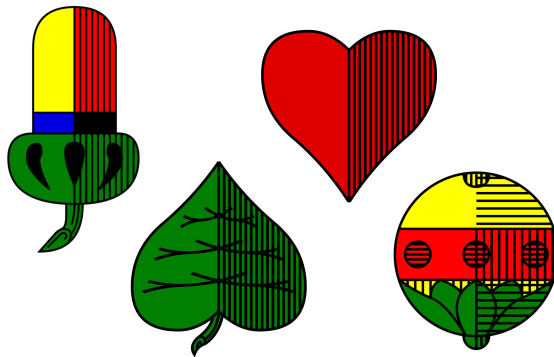


SCHAFKOPF FOR EXPATS

Calling Aces, Going Solo and Buttering Up Your Game

Brian Junker-Latocha



Second Edition. September 6, 2026

ISBN 978-3-384-54132-1

© Brian Junker-Latocha.
Herm.-Steinhäuser-Str. 18
63065 Offenbach
All rights reserved.

Printing and Distribution (by Commission of the Author):
tredition GmbH
Heinz-Beusen-Stieg 5
22926 Ahrensburg

This work and all of its parts are protected by copyright law. The author, Brian Junker-Latocha, is responsible for its contents. Any reproduction without the permission of the author is forbidden. Published and distributed by commission of the author.

WARUM SCHAFKOPF?

Why get involved in a regional game with a funny deck of cards? I don't live in Bavaria– heck, I don't have any substantial connection to the culture at all!

As an American Ex-Berliner Hessian¹, my profile is pretty far off the run-of-the-mill Schafkopf mark. But as curiosity and availability will have it, I got enamored of the Bayerisches Blatt deck to such a point that I, one slow morning in February 2023, took it upon myself to google "Schafkopf Frankfurt". What I discovered was a lively Schafkopfverein, just a short subway ride from my flat. Ever since, I've been spreading the Schafkopf gospel to friends and acquaintances from around the Rhine-Main Area² and the world.

¹Inhabitant of the federal state of Hesse.

²Region around Frankfurt, Wiesbaden and Mainz.

Warum Englisch?

The Schafkopfverein Royal Frankfurt³ is an active club of about 30 Schafkopfer and Schafkopferinnen. The Bavarian quota crests somewhere between 90 and 95%, many of whom are tried-and-true veterans who learned to count trumps before they learned to drink beer– and in Bavaria that’s saying something!

From the west at the Frankfurt Schafkopfverein, I soon wandered east. And after having gained my bearings and my confidence (and lost many rounds of shots), I knocked on the door of a small Schafkopf circle just beyond the Weißwurst Equator⁴... in Bavaria. Minus the occasional curse in the local dialect– and with the plus of having brought fresh money to their table– I was readily accepted among the Alzenau Schafkopfers, and I still try to visit that friendly group whenever I can.

But back to my hometown, Frankfurt’s hate-loved little brother with an unrivaled immigrant base: Offenbach am Main.

It started as a quest for cheap entertainment with some friends at my local Kneipe⁵, and led, in mid 2022, to the informal foundation of the Card Table Offenbach– a bona fide card society, complete with the frilly sort of standing table flag popular with German old men’s clubs.

³Website: svr-frankfurt.de

⁴A fictional border separating regions that eat white sausage.

⁵German pub.



Figure 1: Our proud banner

We played 66⁶ till the cows came home. We annointed an Offenbacher Meister and engraved his name on a tin plate. And as our traditional card players' community grew, so, too, did my eagerness to assemble a regular group of four in Offenbach and proselytize them on my newest reason for Dasein⁷, Schafkopf!

The Albanian, Indian and Polish friends I showed it first caught on quick (after all, they'd been primed with a six-month dose of 66). The four-person dynamic with the changing partner captured their attention, and, soon enough, they were cursing and rejoicing to the ebb and flow of the game and the height of their trick⁸ stack.

⁶Two-player trick taker also known as Schnapsen.

⁷Existence.

⁸Set of (four) cards won with a high card.

Fast-forward a few months, and we now have a solid Offenbach base of Indians, Albanians, Polish, a Mexican, an American, an Iranian, some Hessians, and even a few indigenous Bavarians!



Figure 2: Card Table Offenbach playing Schafkopf

Nochmal, warum Englisch?

So again the question, why English? Our modest card club has a good backbone of new players looking to learn– and of old hares⁹ looking to get back in shape and have some fun.

There are great resources out there on Schafkopf strategy– if you can read German. However, sad as that may be, ex-

⁹"Alte Hasen" (experienced players).

pats will be expats. In the words of card-playing expat Oscar Wilde, "Life's too short to learn German!".

For all the Oscar Wildes out there, let this book be your work-around:

Life's too short not to learn Schafkopf!

CONTENTS

Warum Schafkopf?	i
Warum Englisch?	ii
Nochmal, warum Englisch?	iv
 o1 The Rules	 1
o1.1 The Setup	1
o1.2 Object of the Game	2
o1.3 How to Choose the Game: Bidding	8
o1.4 Scoring	11
o1.5 End of Game	14
o1.6 Variants	14
o1.7 Recommended Apps	16
 o2 The Partner Game	 19
o2.1 Introduction	19
o2.2 Playing as the Ace Caller	19
o2.3 Playing as the Called Partner	28
o2.4 Defending a Partner Game	36
 o3 Going Solo	 45
o3.1 Playing a Suit Solo	45

CONTENTS

o3.2	Defending a Suit Solo	56
o3.3	Playing a Wenz or Geier	65
o3.4	Defending a Wenz or Geier	72
o4	Ramsch	81
o5	English Schafkopf Glossary	91
o6	More Games with Bavarian Cards	103
o6.1	66	103
o6.2	Schnauz	109
o6.3	Three-Player Schafkopf	112
o6.4	Lake Constance Jass	115
o6.5	Solitaire	120

O1

THE RULES

01.1 The Setup

Schafkopf is played with a 36-card Bavarian or Franconian (Bayerisches Blatt/Fränkisches Blatt) deck, from which the 6s have been removed. 7s through aces remain for total of 32 cards in the game.

After shuffling, the player to the right of the dealer must cut the deck, after which eight cards are dealt to each player, either in two packs of four, or four packs of two.

The dealer rotates, and the game is dealt and played clockwise.



Figure 01.1: The Bavarian deck

01.2 Object of the Game

The aim of the game is, as a player, to take 61 points, or, as a defender, to take at least 60 points (of 120 total). Each card denomination (ace, 10, king, etc.) has a specific point value.

Taking Tricks

Each game consists of eight tricks, and the trick is taken by the player who plays the highest-ranked card of the led suit (or the highest trump). You must follow suit if possible (only when you don't have any of the led suit can you trump or discard).

Following Suit

Following suit means you must play a card of the led suit if possible (if not, you may play any card). If a trump is led, you must play trump if you can. Note that trump cards do not count as the suit printed on the card (but as trumps). In each new trick, the winner of the previous trick chooses the suit to be followed by playing the first card.

Choosing the Game

After dealing, players bid for the right to choose the game, starting with the player left of the dealer (the forehand).

Schafkopf has three game options:

- **Partner Game**
 - 14 trumps (overs¹, unders² and all hearts)
- **Wenz**
 - Four trumps (only the unders)
- **Suit Solo**³
 - 14 trumps (overs, unders and a suit of your choice)

Partner Game

The most frequent game in Schafkopf, and statistically the easiest, is the partner game. In this game, the player calls

¹Equivalent to the queen in regular cards. German "Ober".

²Equivalent to the jack. German "Unter".

³German "Farbsolo".

an ace she doesn't hold, but in whose suit she holds at least one card.

The aces that can be called are the ace of acorns, ace of leaves or ace of bells. The ace of hearts can't be called, because in partner games it's one of the trump cards. There are 14 trumps.

In a partner game, the defender team will try to search for the called ace as soon as possible by playing a card of that suit. Knowing who has that ace will ensure you don't accidentally give away points to the wrong person. **If someone searches for the called ace, you are required to play it if you have it, even if it will be lost.** You also are not allowed to butter the called ace, meaning toss it into your partner's trick when you couldn't follow suit. You are always allowed to lead with the called ace.

Special rule "running away": if you have four cards of the suit of the called ace, you are allowed to "run away" by playing a different card of that suit *when you lead*. You can only do this when you lead (play the first card). If you ran away like this, you are then allowed play the ace like any other card (e.g. withhold it when its suit is played or butter it into a partner's trick).

When you can't call an ace: If there is no ace which you don't have and of whose suit you don't have at least one card, you are *blocked* and can't initiate a partner game, though you can still be called yourself.

Here is an overview of the cards in a partner game by rank (trumps in gray):

THE RULES

Cards by Trick Rank	Point Value
Over of Acorns	3
Over of Leaves	3
Over of Hearts	3
Over of Bells	3
Under of Acorns	2
Under of Leaves	2
Under of Hearts	2
Under of Bells	2
Ace of Hearts	11
Ten of Hearts	10
King of Hearts	4
Nine of Hearts	0
Eight of Hearts	0
Seven of Hearts	0
Ace of Other Suit	11 (x3)
Ten of Other Suit	10 (x3)
King of Other Suit	4 (x3)
Nine of Other Suit	0 (x3)
Eight of Other Suit	0 (x3)
Seven of Other Suit	0 (x3)
SUM	120

As the offense team (the players), you hopefully chose to play because you have a lot of trumps, so it's your aim to play these again and again to pull trumps from the opponents. Once the opponents are trumpless, it's much easier to make tricks, even with low cards (because you have to follow suit).

Wenz



Figure 01.2: The wenz of your dreams

Wenz is a game with only the four unders as trumps. It can be a good game to play if you have lots of aces, but few potential trumps and equally distributed suits. Wenz and solo are the two games you play alone, one against three—but you still need to take home 61 points!

In a Wenz, it's very important which unders you have and whose turn it is to be forehand, or the person to play the first card.

Even if you have only one or two unders, if you play the first card, you can sometimes pull all the opponents' unders in a single attempt. Whenever you don't play first, it's best you don't have any high scoring cards like a 10 without also holding the respective ace—otherwise these high-scorers may fall prey to opponents' aces. Note that in Wenz, the overs are ranked below the kings.

Card ranks in a Wenz:

Cards by Trick Rank	Point Value
Under of Acorns	2
Under of Leaves	2
Under of Hearts	2
Under of Bells	2
Ace	11 (x4)
Ten	10 (x4)
King	4 (x4)
Over	3 (x4)
Nine	0 (x4)
Eight	0 (x4)
Seven	0 (x4)
SUM	120

Suit Solo

A suit solo is a one-on-three game in which the bid winner gets to choose the trump suit. Suit solos have 14 trumps, just like partner games.

In a solo, it's particularly beneficial to have as few non-trump suits as possible, especially if you are not the first to play. If an opponent plays an ace of a non-trump you also have in your hand, you are not able to take it with a trump, because you have to follow suit. In this case your opponents may butter in high value cards for their team to take home.

Here are the cards by rank in a suit solo:

Cards by Trick Rank	Point Value
Over of Acorns	3
Over of Leaves	3
Over of Hearts	3
Over of Bells	3
Under of Acorns	2
Under of Leaves	2
Under of Hearts	2
Under of Bells	2
Ace of Trump	11
Ten of Trump	10
King of Trump	4
Nine of Trump	0
Eight of Trump	0
Seven of Trump	0
Ace of Other Suit	11 (x3)
Ten of Other Suit	10 (x3)
King of Other Suit	4 (x3)
Nine of Other Suit	0 (x3)
Eight of Other Suit	0 (x3)
Seven of Other Suit	0 (x3)
SUM	120

01.3 How to Choose the Game: Bidding

The forehand (player left of dealer) is the first person to bid, and she indicates her willingness to choose a game by saying "I would play" (regardless of the game she has in mind).

The next player then can either bid a higher game (partner game < Wenz < suit solo), or say "pass". If the next player

passes, the remaining players also have the chance to bid a game or pass. If a player wants to outbid, they must say what they would play (partner game/Wenz/solo), and then the original bidder has a chance to outbid, or to rescind their partner-game bid and let the higher bidder play⁴. If everyone passes, a negative game called Ramsch (German for junk) is played⁵, each man for himself trying to make the **least** number of points possible.

Bidding Examples

A: I would play

B: pass

C: pass

D: I would also play, a Wenz

A: ok, it's yours.

Result: Player D plays a Wenz

A: pass

B: I would play

C: pass

D: pass

Result: Player B plays whatever she chooses.

A: I would play

B: I would also play, a Wenz

C: pass

⁴Players who outbid may not rescind their bid.

⁵Some rounds also just redeal instead of playing Ramsch.

D: pass

A: I have a solo

Result: Player A plays a solo

A: pass

B: pass

C: pass

D: pass

Result: Everyone plays "Ramsch" for the least points possible.

Last Chance to Outbid

A suit solo is higher than a Wenz is higher than a partner game. If a player before you bids a higher game, there is, however, still one way to outbid: "tout"⁶.

A Wenz or suit solo announced as tout outranks any regular solo, and means you will take every single trick. If you don't, you lose the game.

Bid
Suit Solo Tout
Wenz Tout
Suit Solo
Wenz
Partner Game

⁶French for "all".

01.4 Scoring

The ways of scoring Schafkopf vary from round to round and group to group. Nonetheless, there are a few constant elements.



Figure 01.3: Keeping it old-school

Partner Game, Wenz, Solo

One-on-three games (Wenz and suit solo) are worth the same score, and partner games are worth a lesser score. A typical approach to scoring is to assign partner games the value 20 and Wenz and solo both 40⁷.

This means that if the solo/Wenz player wins, each other "pays" them 40 points:

⁷10 and 50, or 10 and 40 are also common scorings.

Brian	Hans	Christian	Jürgen
120	-40	-40	-40

If the solo/Wenz player loses, the opposite happens:

Brian	Hans	Christian	Jürgen
-120	40	40	40

In a partner game, both members of the offense win or lose together:

Brian	Hans	Christian	Jürgen
20	-20	20	-20

Ramsch

Ramsch can be scored with each winner earning +10 and each "virgin" earning +20⁸ (a virgin is a player with no points at the end of the round). The loser pays. In the below example, Jürgen had the most points and Hans had 0 points in his tricks:

Brian	Hans	Christian	Jürgen
10	20	10	-40

⁸Some rounds stipulate each virgin doubles the overall value of the round instead.

Winning Levels

Schneider

If the playing party scores 61 or the defending scores 60, they have won the game.

If they did a really good job, they may have won "schneider" meaning with a huge point majority. For this, the playing party must score 91 or the defending party 90.

Winning "schneider" makes the game worth another ten points (instead of 20 each):

Brian	Hans	Christian	Jürgen
30	-30	30	-30

Schwarz

If either party wins every single trick, it's called winning "schwarz" or black. This makes the game worth yet another 10 points. Thus, an partner game won schwarz would be scored, instead of 20, as such:

Brian	Hans	Christian	Jürgen
40	-40	40	-40

Contra

As a member of the defender team, at any time before you play your first card, you may say "contra" to double the value

of the game (whether won or lost). Only do this if you are very certain of yourself, i.e. you have a ton of trumps⁹.

Tout

When a tout is played, schneider and schwarz are disregarded and the value of the game is doubled.

01.5 End of Game

Before starting, it is often agreed to play a "list" of a given number of games which is a multiple of four (to give everyone an equal number of times as forehand).

At the end of the list, if you kept score right, the final sums will themselves add up to zero. The winner is the one with the most points, and the loser buys the next round :)

01.6 Variants

Geier and Farbwenz

In addition to Wenz and suit solo, some rounds also allow:

- Geier
 - Only the overs are trump (four trumps total)
- Farbwenz
 - Only the unders and a whole suit of your choice are trump (11 trumps total)

⁹Theoretically, an offense player can double-down and say "re" before playing her second card, again doubling the game value.

Laufende

Many rounds play that the value of the game is increased if one team has three or more "Laufende"¹⁰. Laufende are the highest trumps in sequential order. E.G: if either team has the over of acorns, over of leaves and over of hearts, that game costs five more each, for a total of 15 more– whether lost or won.

In a Wenz or Geier, Laufende are counted from two or more.

Doubling

Some rounds allow doubling the game value. To play this way, you must deal the cards in packages of four– before looking at the second package, each player can put a chip on the table or knock to double the value of the round. But be careful! Your next four cards could be junk. And sometimes multiple players double. When someone doubles, take that as a signal that they have good cards.

Playing for Money

Instead of points, use coins. One point equals one cent.

Durchmarsch in Ramsch

Usually the highest score loses in Ramsch. But if you play with "Durchmarsch", accumulate 91 points and the tables turn: you win the Ramsch for the value of a solo!

¹⁰German for "runners".

Redealing

Instead of playing Ramsch, when everyone passes, new hands are dealt to all. Often, this is done in combination with a solo pot¹¹, into which every player pays 10 cents as a penalty.

Playing with Five or Six

It's possible to play with more than four players, up to a max of six.

- If five are playing, the dealer doesn't play.
- If six are playing, the dealer and the cutter (to her right) both don't play. Playing with six players tends to lead to dwindling attention spans...

01.7 Recommended Apps

- bayerisch-schafkopf.de
 - Nice for statistics.
 - Also has great introductory "training" lessons that are interactive (but in German).
- schafkopf-palast.de
 - Popular for online playing.

¹¹The next solo additionally wins the pot, or must double it, if lost.

- sausspiel.de
 - There is an iPhone app and it runs in the browser with Android.
 - The rules allow doubling and the format is quite nice for a few quick games with human opponents.

O2

THE PARTNER GAME

o2.1 Introduction

The following chapters accompany you through the decisions of playing a partner game. They are just examples, but attempt to explain basic concepts and rules of thumb in an approachable way. We begin each example after the deal.

o2.2 Playing as the Ace Caller

So¹, it's time to bid, and, lucky you, you're first in line. You look at your hand and see these are your cards: over of acorns,

¹"Wer so sagt ist noch lange nicht fertig!"

over of bells, under of hearts, king of hearts, ace of leaves,
10 of acorns, 8 of bells and 7 of bells:



Time to introduce the first golden rule of bidding: if you have four trumps and an ace on the side, go for it!

Being first to play, you're also first to announce, so let's think: the heart can't be called, and you have the leaf ace, so it's either the bell or the acorn ace. Is one better than the other? Yes, because with each additional card you have of the called suit, the higher the likelihood an opponent will be empty in that suit— and will stick your pig²! Plus, if acorns go through³, you have at least an ace and a 10 in that trick, 21 points.

After this necessary deliberation, you're ready to go, and say "I would play". No one wants to outbid you, so the game is yours, and you announce with confidence, "I'm playing with the acorn!".

You're up first, so what's your first move? **When you play, trump's the way!**

Having bid for and won the right to play, you believe you and your partner have the trump power to control the game and hopefully pull the opponents' trumps with more left to spare. When you play, trump's the way— so we'll lead with a trump:

²Trump the called ace.

³If all players have an acorn

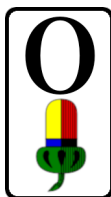
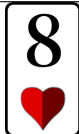


Figure O2.1: The over of acorns, the game's highest card.

At the beginning, it's important to retain control of the game with your high trumps. This way we can minimize opponent's trump power early on, and their likelihood to trump the called ace. We play our highest trump, the unbeatable over of acorns. Let's see what we take in:

First Trick

You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert
			

Good job, you pulled three trumps! Whoops— **were you counting?** We started with 14, we had four in our hand, that's ten, minus the three we just took home. That means seven trumps are still out there.

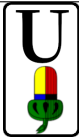
Let's try to get them— maybe we can even stay in control! Here's your hand:



You made the last trick, so you lead now. You don't know who has the next trumps from the top (over of leaves and of hearts), but who knows, maybe your partner has them (whoever he or she may be).

You play a low trump⁴, the king of hearts. This gives your partner the chance to use a high trump. Wouldn't it be great if he or she had the leaf or heart over? It's a crap shoot, but either way we succeed in expending more of the opponents' trumps.

Second Trick

You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert
			

LeftyLukas takes it with the over of leaves (the number-two trump). How many trumps are left?

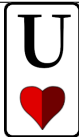
Seven were left before, now three more have turned up. That means only four trumps are left.

So what to do now? You still have no real signal who your partner may be, but let's wait and see. LeftyLukas leads

⁴"Hoch und nieder, immer wieder.": Alternative high and low trumps is good teamwork.

the next trick– with trump. RightyRobert puts in the over of hearts (which you can't possibly beat) so you put in your lowest remaining trump:

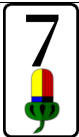
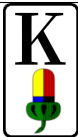
Third Trick

LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You
			

The fact LeftyLukas led trump was a magic signal– offense players lead trump ("if you play, trump's the way"). So Lukas is probably your partner. But how many trumps are still out? There were four left. Minus three: now there's just one left.

We're going take that magic signal at face value and assume LeftyLukas is our partner. RightyRobert made the last trick, so it's his turn to lead. He plays an acorn– he's searching for the called ace!

Fourth Trick

RightyRobert	You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze
			

It went through⁵, congrats. No one was empty in acorns and your team secured itself an A, 10 and K. Thus, you now officially know who your partner is: "Hello, LeftyLukas!".

It's your partner's turn now, since the ace was his. Here's our hand:



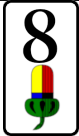
And here's the situation:

Fifth Trick

LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You
			...

We don't have any acorns, so we could trump. But there's zero points on the table! And we're going to need that trump to pull the last remaining trump, which we know is below our over of bells (we already saw all the other overs). No need to waste a trump here. Instead, we can dump some junk and get rid of a worthless low bell (one reason why this was a dumb move on our defenders' part):

⁵Everyone had an acorn to play.

LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You
			

RightyRobert took that cheap trick (0 points), so now he leads. He plays a king of leaves:

Sixth Trick

RightyRobert	You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze
	...	...	...

Here's your hand, and you're up. What will you play?



The leaf ace, of course (we have to follow suit). Lucky for us, this suit hasn't gone through yet, so chances are, the last two still have leaves– and they do:

RightyRobert	You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze
			

Now, remember how many trumps were left out? Still just one more, and we saw all the other overs hit the table. "If you play, trump's the way", so we'll play that last over and collect the final outstanding trump from the other players. It works like a charm:

Seventh Trick

Trumps ade⁶!

You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert
			

We extracted the last trump from RightyRobert, and now have just one final card. Unfortunately, it's the 8 of bells, and not going to make us any more points:

Eighth Trick

The last trick is theirs, but we win safely with 80 points, a bit shy of schneider (91). That's 20 points plus for the two players, and 20 minus for the defenders!

⁶German for adieu, pronounced "ah-day".

You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert
			

Lessons Learned

- **Bid for a partner game when you have at least four trumps and a side ace.**
 - Five trumps without a side ace is also acceptable if you have a couple good overs.
 - These are rules of thumb, develop your own mental rule as you go.
- **Partner with the ace in which suit you have the fewest cards.**
 - This decreases the probability of an opponent being empty in that suit and "sticking your pig" with a trump.
- **"If you play, trump's the way!"**
 - As soon as you lead, begin pulling trumps and don't stop– the majority should be on your team's side.
- **If you have the top trump– start with it.**
 - In the next trick, give your partner a chance to take over (alternate high and low trumps). This

avoids pulling your partner's high trumps with your own.

- **If you don't have the top trump, you can play a low trump and hope your partner takes it.**

- Either way, you've pulled more trumps.

- **Count trumps, count trumps, count trumps.**

- Most count down from what's missing or outstanding, but you can also count up to 14.

02.3 Playing as the Called Partner

Playing as the called partner is governed by largely the same strategy as for the caller– with the difference that you may or may not be thick in trumps.

Let's try another example. Here's your hand:



Ok, two trumps are in our hand and 12 remain out. This time, the player to our right is first. RightyRobert looks at his hand and, after some deliberation, says "I pass". It's your turn. Two trumps, all the suits and a couple aces. Not a player's hand, but with two callable aces we will probably be called as a partner. Let's wait and see. We pass.

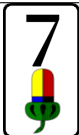
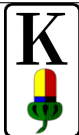
LeftyLukas also passes, leaving MiddleMatze to decide whether to play or relegate us all to Ramsch. He says with gusto: "I'm playing with the acorn!".

Lucky for us, we have the acorn ace, so we're the partner! Let's hope our hand is strong enough to support Matze with enough trumps and points. Could be tight.

This deal, it's RightyRobert's turn to start. He looks around the table, smiles, and blurts out "contra!" before he lays his first card, the 9 of acorns. He's feeling confident enough to double the game value; he must have a lot of trumps.

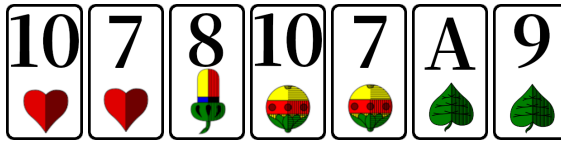
Remember, when someone "searches", you have to play the called ace, so put it down, and hope for the best! You get lucky– the acorns go through⁷, and your ace survives:

First Trick

RightyRobert	You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze
			

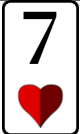
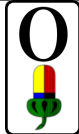
"Hello, Matze!" He's your new partner, welcome to the offense team. It's your turn now. Here's your hand:

⁷Survive untrumped.



"If you play, trump's the way!" This is just as valid for the partner as for the caller. Let's play trump and hope our partner will take the trick with a high one. It's a crap shoot who has the current top trump, though, so let's hold back the 10 of hearts for now and play the 7 of hearts:

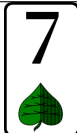
Second Trick

You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert
			

Ok, fairly cheap trick for the opponents– and the over of acorns is gone (good thing we kept the 10). How many trumps does that leave us with? We started with two, so 12 out, minus these three makes for nine trumps left in the game.

RightyRobert is up, and he plays the king of leaves. We have the ace and it's the first leaf trick, so let's assert control and play it.

Third Trick

RightyRobert	You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	
				

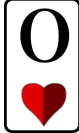
Great, we're back in the lead: what to play? Our hand:

				
---	---	---	---	---

"If you play, trump's the way!" Our last trump is the 10. It's a risk to play it, because we don't know who has the top trump (currently the over of hearts). At the same time, we want to keep pulling trumps– and maybe our partner has that bad boy. So we take the risk and play the 10 of hearts.

Fourth Trick

And Matze takes it home with the over! More points for us!

You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert
			

How many trumps are left now? There were nine, minus three equals six trumps still out. Let's see what Matze is planning:

Fifth Trick

MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You	LeftyLukas
		...	...

Ouch, that was the top trump, the over of bells– and Robert's partner, Lukas, comes last. It's their trick for sure,

and Lukas will butter⁸ if he can. We can't do much more than damage control. Our cards:



No trumps left, of course. The best move in this type of situation would be to get empty in some suit to make it easier to butter that 10 later. So we choose one of our singletons— the 9 of leaves:

MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You	LeftyLukas

That one's theirs. And three more trumps means, instead of six, now only three are left in play. RightyRobert leads next with his king of bells. Who's got the ace? This could be snug!

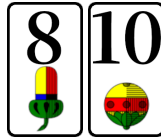
⁸Put high points in your partner's tricks, especially when you can't follow suit.

Sixth Trick

RightyRobert	You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze
			

Phew! Your partner had the ace. You didn't know who had it, and bells hadn't gone through yet, so you decided to play low-risk with the 7 of bells. Well, low risk, low gain! You could have got more out of that one with your 10. Nonetheless, your team wins an ace and a king, and you start to smell the scent of victory...

Now, how many trumps are left? Still three— so who's got 'em?! Everyone has two cards left. Yours are:



Partner MiddleMatze leads with a butter trump⁹ (ace of hearts). He knows I'm trumpless, I hope he knows what he's doing!

⁹An ace or 10 of trump.

Seventh Trick

MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You	LeftyLukas
			

Ouch! Robert takes it with his under! Will we still make it? The last trump (there's one left now) is ours, surely?! Here's the final trick:

Eighth Trick

RightyRobert	You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze
			

Dagnabb it! Robert leads the last trump– that's even more points for them... But, lo and behold, it's not enough! Matze and you collected 70 points in the beginning and middle stages of the game! This duck wasn't fat in the butt¹⁰ – at least not fat enough for Robert and Lukas. A partner game is worth 20 points, doubled with Robert's contra makes 40 points owed to Matze and you. Congratulations.

¹⁰Original saying: "Hinten ist die Ente fett".

Lessons Learned

- **Let yourself be called.**
 - With a hand that's not quite good enough, it can be better to bet on being called—especially if you have one or more callable aces yourself.
- **Keep the trump pressure on.**
 - "If you play, trump's the way!"
 - Even if you have to risk a high-point trump, if your partner comes after you, she may still take over the trick with a higher one.
 - Exploiting your trump majority to pull trumps is key as a player.

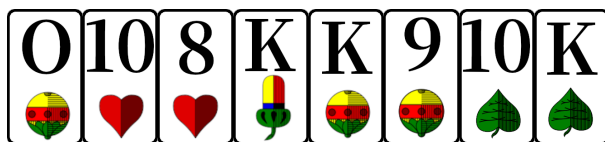
02.4 Defending a Partner Game

Congratulations

Congratulations, your team won two games as players! Statistically speaking, you're likely to win most partner games as a player. The bad news? You'll lose most you play on the defense.

Let's have a look at how a partner game as a defender can shape up. Depending on how lucky the caller gets with her choice of partner, a partner game on defense can often be a matter of making the best out of a bad situation.

How bad can it be? Here's your hand:



You're last to play, and LeftyLukas starts the bidding off saying, "I'll play!". The rest of the table passes. Looking at our three-trump, garden salad¹¹ of a hand, we also pass. LeftyLukas proclaims: "With the acorn!". So let's keep our eyes peeled for that ace of acorns, which will be his partner.

How many trumps are out there? 14 in a partner game, minus three in our hand equals eleven left.

First Trick

LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You

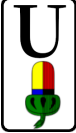
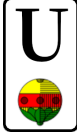
LeftyLukas, the caller, leads with the top trump. MiddleMatze goes low, he couldn't take it if he wanted to. RightyRobert drops the king and you put in your lowest trump, always trying to save higher-ranked ones in case they make a trick later.

How many trumps left? 11 before, minus three equals eight trumps remaining!

Back to LeftyLukas:

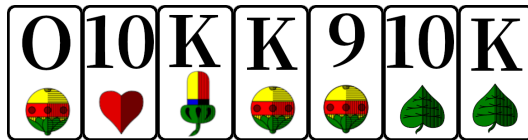
¹¹ Evenly mixed hand with all the suits.

Second Trick

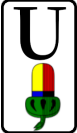
LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You
			...

Lukas leads with an under, and Matze takes over the trick with the current top trump, the over of leaves. RightyRobert puts in his presumably lowest trump, knowing he's losing the trick (and possibly knowing he's not Matze's partner).

Now, we don't know for sure who the partner is, and ideally we'd like to take over this trick and search for the called ace with an acorn. But we can't top the leaf over. Instead of wasting a potential trick-taker, we put in the 10 of hearts from this hand:

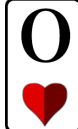


If we're lucky, MiddleMatze might even be our partner. Here's the full trick:

LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You
			

Now things get interesting. Will MiddleMatze play trump, or look for the acorn ace himself? Eight trumps were left previously, minus three from this trick equals five trumps left out.

Third Trick

MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You	LeftyLukas
			

Ok! Shame, it seems MiddleMatze is our opponent, he led a trump. That would mean Robert is our prospective partner. You give it your best with your over of bells, but Lukas' over of hearts takes it home from the back. Things are not looking good for us. Five trumps before, minus three equals two trumps left (and we're empty).

Here's our hand:



Fourth Trick

LeftyLukas leads again:

LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You
			...

Oh, nice! Player Lukas was betting his partner had that last trump, but we did, Robert did! The trick is ours, so butter in what you can, in this case, the green 10.

LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You
			

Great, our first points. *Die Hoffnung stirbt zuletzt*¹²... On to the next trick.

Fifth Trick

Here's your hand:



Partner Robert leads a bell. I guess he hopes we have the ace (bells haven't gone through yet):

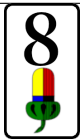
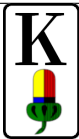
¹²"Hope dies last."

RightyRobert	You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze
			

Ouch! Points for them!

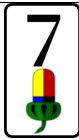
Sixth Trick

MiddleMatze leads with the called ace– the trumps are all gone at this point, so he's safe. You have the king and have to follow:

MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You	LeftyLukas
			

Seventh Trick

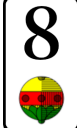
MiddleMatze leads a low acorn, possibly hoping it's the last one and he can take the trick with it (it can help to count suit cards, too):

MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You	LeftyLukas
			

Oh, dear. That's exactly what he does, and his partner Lukas butters in the ace of leaves. There's not much we can do.

Eighth Trick

Matze leads yet again, and what worked once will work a second time... He plays the final acorn to secure the king and thereby the final four points of the game:

MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You	LeftyLukas
			

The game ends with a whopping 97 points for the offense, we lose *schneider*¹³, and thus pay each of our opponents not 20 but 30 points. Lady luck was against us, there was not much more we could do.

Lessons Learned

- **Don't lead trump!**
 - As a defender, it almost never makes sense to lead trump. You're usually in the trump minority, and any trumps that don't get pulled you should save for taking tricks in suits you are empty or could become empty in.

¹³With less than 30 points

- "If you play, trump's the way."
 - * If you don't, **it's not**.
- **Try to get empty in suits¹⁴.**
 - The faster you're empty in a suit, the easier you can trump and take control– or the more flexibly you can butter up your partner.
- **Withhold high cards from opponents whenever possible.**
 - Save them for buttering in later.
 - Sometimes it can make sense to sacrifice a high-point trump instead of putting in a low-point, high-ranked one that may take a whole trick later.
 - * For example, in the second trick, we gave away a 10 of hearts in the hopes of taking a later trump trick with our over of bells (it didn't work, but, hey, it could have).

¹⁴The word suits is usually used in contrast to trumps.

03

GOING SOLO

Unlike with the partner game, there is no cut-and-dry rule for when you should attempt a solo. You are much more dependent on the distribution of the cards among the other players, making it much more important to focus on the fine print, like what position you're playing in, exactly which trumps and side cards you have, and whether someone already bid or doubled.

03.1 Playing a Suit Solo

In a suit solo¹, recall there are 14 trumps, just like in a partner game. In general, you'll need at least six of these to have a

¹German "Farbsolo".

good chance at winning. But the devil's in the details! Here are the main factors that will influence your chances to win a suit solo:

- **Your position at the table.**

- If you're first, it's usually easier, because you can start the game off with a trump trick.
- If you're fourth, it's not bad either, because you're in the back, in a position to react and or trump what your opponents played.
- If you're in the middle, i.e. second or third, it's a weaker position.

- **Your side cards.**

- Do you have more than one side suit? Suboptimal. Do you have more than one side suit and no ace? Even worse.
- If an opponent plays before you and leads one of these suits, you'll be losing big points (especially if you have a freestanding² 10).

- **Your trumps.**

- Do you have one or more of the butter trumps?
 - * This will make pulling trumps less dangerous, and is especially good if you plan lose some trump tricks (because you don't have the top trumps).

²As a singleton of that suit.

- * Having the trump butter yourself ensures lost trump tricks won't be too fat.
- If you don't have the butter trumps, it's more crucial to have some high rankers: overs and high unders.
- * You'll need those guys to retain control and hopefully take some butter trumps home.

Beware of Heart Solo

Another factor in your choice to play a solo affects you most when you're considering a *heart* solo: the other players!

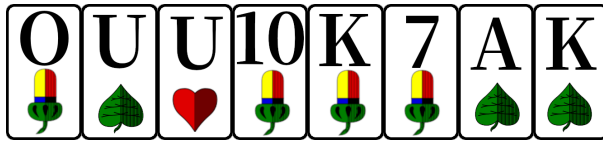
If someone before you already bid, it's likely to have been with a partner game in mind, meaning they are thick in trumps and the distribution is uneven. An uneven distribution is bad, and means you need more trumps to exhaust the defending team's trump supply. The same is true if someone doubled— they likely have a decent collection of trumps, usually *hearts*.

While this is less relevant if you play an acorn, leaf or bell solo, the point still applies to the distribution of the overs and unders, so be careful if you don't have the big boys³ in your own hand.

A Doable Solo?

Let's give the game a try. You're sitting in first position, here's your hand:

³The top overs and unders.



You're first up. Ok, you have six trumps and only one side suit– and you have a side ace! Plus you have the top over, always a bonus. So let's give it a go: "I'll play".

LeftyLukas passes, as do MiddleMatze and RightyRobert. Your hand is not good enough for a partner game with hearts as trump. But that's not our only option:

We have a pretty strong... acorn solo! Having only one side suit, we'll be able to trump hearts and bells if an opponent leads them. But for now, we'll do as players do: "If you play, trump's the way!".

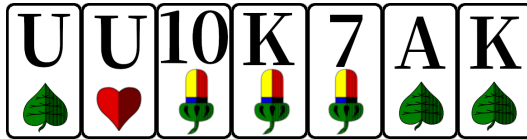
One over, two unders and three acorns. That's six trumps with us and– 14 minus six equals eight trumps with the opponents. We have the highest, and we lead, so let's play from the top (this way we retain control, and can follow this trump round with another):

First Trick

You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert

Alles klar⁴, as expected, no one gifted you the ace of trump. But we did pull an over. Let's pull some more trumps, but first things first: there were eight trumps before, minus three makes *five* trumps left in circulation.

Here's our hand now:



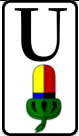
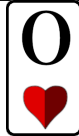
We're missing several of the top trumps (leaf over, heart over, acorn under), so we're going to have to bet on losing a trump trick or two. Nonetheless, let's put one of our precious unders into the trick. Yes, we will likely lose this one. But it means the opponents will at least expend a high trump, and can't take a trick with the ace of trump, preserving their high trumps (very annoying).

We give the under of hearts a whirl. It could also have made sense to preserve the under and play our lowest trump, knowing it's going to be lost anyway. But the trump ace is still out, so we at least want them to pay high if they're going to get it:

Second Trick

Ok: LeftyLukas realized we're weak on top trumps, and bargained wisely that his friends might have a high-enough one to beat our under of hearts (he risked the ace of trump).

⁴"Alles klar, Herr Kommissar?"

You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert
			

Matze secures the trick with the acorn under, and Robert, surprisingly, puts an even higher trump in. He probably wouldn't have wasted it if he had had a choice (the trick was already theirs).

Five trumps were left last, now three more have fallen, so just two remain out. The defenders lead, and Robert starts with a heart:

Third Trick

RightyRobert	You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze
	...	...	...

Great, a suit you don't have:



Plus, it's being played for the very first time, so the ace and 10 are still out there. Trump it! Just to be safe, we secure

the ten points from our 10 of acorns (we're empty in hearts, so we hope everyone has hearts and no one will overtrump⁵ us:

RightyRobert	You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze
			

Not too shabby! Another 24 points. The ace of hearts is still out there, but we got the 10, and we're back in control. Trump status? Still two remain! And we've been keeping an eye on the overs, and noticed that the leaf over hasn't been played yet.

We will lose this trick, but it's still in our best interest to eliminate the enemy trumps, especially if we have more left: "If you play, trump's the way!". Our options:

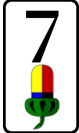


Now, we think the enemy over of leaves will take this trick, but we can't remember what else is missing. If we're lucky, the two outstanding trumps are distributed, and both will fall into this trick. If we're unlucky, they're clumped with one player, and the trumpless others will do their best to butter, butter, butter.

Here we go:

⁵Trump our trump with a higher one.

Fourth Trick

You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert
			

Not bad. Lukas had the over and trumpless Robert but-tered in an ace. Could have been much worse– at least the trumps are all gone! And we still have two left. We smile deviously behind our poker face as we look at our hand:



And Lukas leads.

Fifth Trick

LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You
			

Oh⁶, how fortuitous! Lukas hoped his team might have the green ace and instead, he led the trick right into ours.

We're back in control, and here's our hand:

⁶"Ach du grüne Neune!"



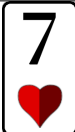
Well, well, well: the enemy trumps are all out, what do we do? If you recall correctly, the green 10 fell into the last trick, leaving our king of green high. A high card, no trumps on the opponents' side, and two in our hand?! The rest is ours! You can savor each final trick individually, or put your cards face-up on the table and claim what's rightfully yours. Well done!

You win with 88 points, three shy of schneider (91). For that, each opponent owes you 40 points, for a total of +120 on the chart.

Here are the final three tricks, just for fun:

Sixth Trick

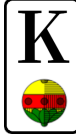
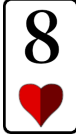
You play the high king, but shoot blanks⁷:

You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert
			

⁷Win a trick, but collect little to no points.

Seventh Trick

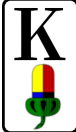
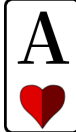
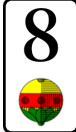
The opponents try to save their butter in the hope against hopes that you will run out of trump:

You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert
			

Not gonna happen.

Eighth Trick

The butter hits the pan, and you finish strong⁸:

You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert
			

Lessons Learned

- **Six trumps with a high over and a single side suit with an ace is a solid basis for a suit solo.**
 - Especially if you're playing first.
- **Playing first makes a big difference.**

⁸The duck is fat in the butt.

- Beginning the game with trump makes us less susceptible to giving away points in our side suit(s), and helps protect any side aces of ours from being trumped.

- **Be careful with your trump butter.**

- Sometimes, it's best to secure it by putting it into the trick of a suit that hasn't run yet. But watch out, sometimes you'll be overtrumped doing this– the worst would be with an ace of trump!
- If you can put it in last you're risk-free.
 - * But you never know how the suit is distributed outside your hand or if an opponent behind you could be empty. If you have enough, it can make sense to play it safe with an under instead.

- **Remember what suit cards are high.**

- Once the enemy trumps are gone, you may have more guaranteed trick takers in your hand.

- **Remember what butter is still out, and how many cards are left in suits.**

- This will help you to evaluate a trump-or-dump situation⁹, especially in estimating the butter risk.

⁹A prickly situation in which you've been brought into the middle and must decide to trump high, trump low, or dump a low-pointer (under risk of enemy butter).

03.2 Defending a Suit Solo

Defending a suit solo is a team effort. It's three-against-one, and your opponent is empty in at least one suit— probably two— and has at least six trumps.

A couple of tips for defending a solo:

- **Put the player in the middle.**
 - The more you can maneuver the player into the middle position, the better (in first position, she can pull trumps, in last position she can react with a trump).
 - By putting the player in second or third position, other players get a chance to overtrump when she trumps a suit trick¹⁰, but more importantly, you force the player into a trump-or-dump dilemma: if she trumps too low, she may be overtrumped, if she dumps, opponents may butter themselves points— especially, especially, especially if that suit was already played and someone is empty!
- **Don't lead a suit ace¹¹ on a player in fourth position.**
 - Obviously, there is a high risk in any suit trick that the solo player will be empty in that suit and will trump.

¹⁰Non-trump trick

¹¹Ace of a non-trump suit

- But even more importantly, even if your ace goes through, what next? Now the player is situated comfortably in the back, read to react to whatever your team does. Instead of leading a suit ace, try another suit– either a partner will take it, possibly putting the player in second or third position, or the player will take it, which would have happened soon anyway. If you're in the happy situation that the player is currently in the middle, you may even force her into a trump-or-dump dilemma.

Let's dive right in and experience a suit solo as a defender. It's a heart solo, and you're first to play:



Three trumps in our hand means 11 trumps left in the game.

First Trick

One thought would be to play an ace. The player is right after us, so if someone is empty, we might even still overtrump a trumping. But it's early in the game and everyone still has all their cards. We have three leaves (of six total in the game) so this might be our only chance to take one home. We risk it with the ace:

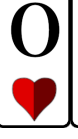
You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert
			

Darn, no dice¹². Now player Lukas is in the lead. What else: he plays trump (11 minus one equals ten trumps left in the game).

Second Trick

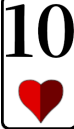
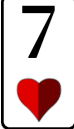
LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You
			...

But it's not the top trump, and partner Matze produces the big boy, the acorn over. Your cards:

						
--	--	--	--	--	--	--

Partner Robert already played some tasty trump butter, and what do we put in? Best go with our lowest trump (in absence of any real butter):

¹²Close, but no cigar.

LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You
			

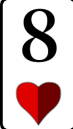
10 trumps before, minus these three, makes seven trumps left in the game!

Third Trick

Partner Matze is up and plays a low bell. Robert smells an opportunity, perhaps, and puts in his 10. But it's too much risk from our perspective: these two bells on the table plus our two equals four, of a total six bells in the deck:



Let's put in our king instead of the ace to hedge the bet¹³.

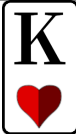
MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You	LeftyLukas
			

That was the right choice. Six trumps left.

¹³Play it safe.

Fourth Trick

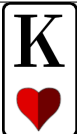
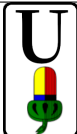
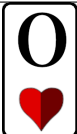
Player Lukas leads, initiating another trump trick:

LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You
			...

Our hand:



The choice is clear, we take it while we can with the over of hearts:

LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You
			

That's three more trumps gone, meaning six minus three, equals three trumps left. It's our turn to lead, with the following hand:



Fifth Trick

Idea: Lukas has no leaves, and we have the last high-point leaf on-hand (the ten, and we played the ace earlier). Let's do a "trump-or-dump" on him and see what happens.

You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert

Ok, he dumped this time– but Matze buttered, and Robert took the trick!

Lukas is back in the middle, and Robert tries the acorn ace (maybe Lukas had two acorns?)¹⁴:

Sixth Trick

RightyRobert	You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze

¹⁴The player is third, not fourth.

Woohoo! It went through, and so did our butter! That was a big risk, especially since Lukas already dumped one acorn. But the butter had to go somewhere, lest it be certainly taken in another trick.

Now Robert's up again, Lukas still in the middle. Here's your hand:



Remember, there are still three trumps out (and player Lukas only has two cards). Robert leads in the seventh trick:

Seventh Trick

RightyRobert	You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze
			

A bell! We have the ace of bells, but we know who's empty in bells... Lukas trumps it, leaving two trumps in the final trick. Will our final card, the under of hearts, be high in the eighth trick?

Our hand:



Eighth Trick

LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You

We lose it to the under of leaves. But that cheap trick is not enough to turn the tide for player Lukas. The defense wins with 68 points! Good job!

Lessons Learned

- **If the player leads with a lower over than the top one, she often has a gap.**
 - Exploit the gap by buttering in anything you can: your teammate can likely take it with the missing trump.
- **Hold back high cards if you have a a lot of their suit.**
 - You may be the only defender who knows it's unlikely to go through.

- Hedge your bets¹⁵ accordingly.

- **Put the player in a sandwich.**

- If you can maneuver the player into second or third position, you can bring her into trouble by leading a suit that already ran.

- * Remember the "trump-or-dump dilemma"!

- If the ace and 10 of that suit are out of the question (in your hand or already played), the player has no points to gain by trumping (because if she does, the defenders will dump junk).

- * However, if she doesn't trump, and instead dumps a card, she opens the door to the defenders behind her buttering for all they're worth!

- If the ace or 10 are still out in the led suit, the player will need to trump high if she wants the points, eliminating a high trick-taker from the game (and possibly granting the defenders another trump trick in return).

- * If she makes the mistake of trumping low, the defenders behind her have a good chance of overtrumping, depending how many trumps have already been pulled at this point, and also whether she's second or third.

¹⁵Withhold your butter if you can see a suit is unlikely to go through.

03.3 Playing a Wenz or Geier

In Wenz and Geier, only four of the 32 cards are trump, either the unders or the overs. This makes it even more important where you sit and how the trumps are distributed—especially if you don't have all four. The rambunctious rule-of-thumb for playing a Wenz applies equally to Geier:

"Beim Wenz spielt man Ässe oder hält die Fresse!"¹⁶

In a Wenz you play aces or shut your pie-hole! Because at best, half the cards in your hand can be trumps, it is of utmost importance what suits you control on the side. Controlling a suit can mean being empty and having enough trumps to trump that suit, or having the ace of that suit (or better yet a sequence from the ace down). Once the trumps are gone, the high cards control the game, and the leading player can do a lot of damage with the top cards. And note that in Wenz or Geier, there are not six, but seven cards in each suit¹⁷! Also, the more freestanding 10s you have, the worse. Chances are, you'll lose them.

But let's get right into it! The deal is done, and your'e sitting pretty in fourth position with the following hand:



¹⁶Rhymes nicely in German

¹⁷Overs (unders in Geier) are underneath the king by trick rank.

Not half bad. You have the top under and three in total, plus you control leaves with the ace and 10, and you're empty in hearts. Your playmates, Lukas, Matze and Robert have all passed. You're a bit weak for a partner game with three trumps, but you might just manage a Wenz¹⁸! There's only one trump out there. If we can just pull it and avoid losing too many points on those low bells, it should work out. LeftyLukas is first– here's the first trick:

First Trick

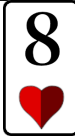
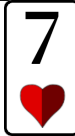
LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You
			

Oh, they chose the right suit from their perspective– but didn't dare butter in all their points in front of a player in fourth position (position has its perks). This is wise in theory, but today we had a bell. RightyRobert is now first again, and you're in the middle.

Second Trick

Well, he didn't put in another bell, but we're still going to have to trump to block the butter here– we're right after Robert in the worst position:

¹⁸"Wenns geht..."

RightyRobert	You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze
			

Ok, they stayed away and let you shoot blanks with your valuable under. Good thing is, we have two left, including the top! Our hand:



"If you play, trump's the way!" This sentence should be enjoyed with caution in a Wenz, given there are only four trumps total. But in this case, we have the highest one, and can extract the leaf under by playing our under of acorns as soon as we take the lead. And out he comes:

Third Trick

You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert
			

We got him, but not much else. We're still in control, and all the trumps are out, so let's inspect our hand in detail:



The 9 of bells is a liability, and we're going to lose points on that one, especially because the suit was already played in the first trick (five bells were played, plus our 9 makes the sixth of seven cards, and the 10 is still out).

Looking at our other cards, the ace and 10 of leaves are in sequence, they will both win. The 7 of leaves should also be the final leaf after those two tricks, which will bring home even more points.

But that pesky 9 of bells! If the suit hadn't already run, and we wouldn't expect a full serving of butter, we would play it now, retaking control later with the final under. This way we could have limited the buttering, because players would have had to follow suit. Well, them's the breaks¹⁹!

With the 10 of bells outstanding, and little butter seen thus far in the game, we can safely assume a lot of points will fall into that bell trick– the question is whether we can afford it.

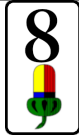
We look in our hand, and decide not to lead that one and hope for less enemy butter by playing top-down:



¹⁹C'est la vie.

Our under and the leaves are all high cards, i.e. trick-takers. Whereas in most cases, we would play the *loser*, bell 9, first, to limit buttering on it (given suit must be followed), we decide to risk leaving the bell 9 until last, because its suit was already played and the 10 is still out.

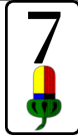
Fourth Trick

You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert
			

As expected, we're shooting blanks (the duck is fat in the butt²⁰).

Fifth Trick

We play our next high card:

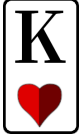
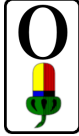
You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert
			

We win some chump change²¹ and continue down the sequence:

²⁰ Big points will fall in the final trick.

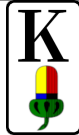
²¹ Peanuts.

Sixth Trick

You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert
			

Moving on, if you remember correctly, two leaves were dumped early on, and four more went into the last two tricks. That leaves but one final leaf (our 7):

Seventh Trick

You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert
			

Nice, some butter in the pan! But, alas, there is still a whole stick of butter in the game, and our 9 of bells just won't cut it! Shame they didn't accidentally dump their 10 of bells instead of 10 of acorns.

Eighth Trick

That, for sure, is a fat one. But it's ok! We won the game in the seventh trick, collecting 70 points in total!

You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert
			

We're in the clear, and each defender (schneider-free²²) owes us 40 points. That's +120 for the scorecard. A job well done.

Lessons Learned

- **Remember what cards are high.**
 - Once the unders are gone, you need to know what cards are guaranteed trick takers, and which are bound to lose.
 - There are seven suit cards in a Wenz or Geier. If you play it right and know your card is last, you can turn a loser into a winner.
- **Seating is very important.**
 - Sitting fourth is not as good as first, which we noticed when the leader started with our low side suit.
- **A side suit without an ace is a liability.**
 - As we saw in this game, 50 points fell into those two bell tricks alone!

²²We did not win schneider (with 91 points).

- One trick less, and we could have been in a tight spot.
- **Keeping control²³ is key in Wenz and Geier.**
 - We had a lot of unders and a sequence of leaves. But if we had lost control after our trumps ran out, our leaf strength would have become a leaf liability:
 - * The opponents would only need to lead another suit to make all our leaves worthless.
 - * Without trumps, we would have no way to wrench back control, and no influence over the suit led.

03.4 Defending a Wenz or Geier

Whether playing or defending, Wenz and Geier are about controlling the suits and dictating the course of the game. This time, you're sitting first, and everyone but LeftyLukas has passed. Lukas announces the unders are trump, so for you, Matze and Robert, the name of the game now is: Wenz defense²⁴! Here's your hand:



²³ Leading the trick is the difference between acting and reacting.

²⁴ *Wen(n)z sein darf...*

We certainly don't have any unders, let's hope Lukas doesn't have them all. Also, we assume our opponent is empty in at least one suit, probably two. We only have one bell, so let's play it to get empty in bells, and maybe even find a partner's ace:

First Trick

You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert
			

Player Lukas trumps with the lowest under, but our partners are able to stay away and let him shoot blanks (besides the 10).

Second Trick

Lukas leads, and his first move is to pull trump:

LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You
	...	...	...

Interesting, he's not starting from the top. Either he has a sequence from the top, and is messing with us, or he really doesn't have it. Wenz defense is a betting game– it could

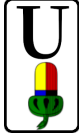
be advantageous for Matze to butter in the hopes that our team will produce the acorn under: and we do!

LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You
			...

Our hand has some butter, so we gladly schmier:

						
---	---	---	---	---	---	---

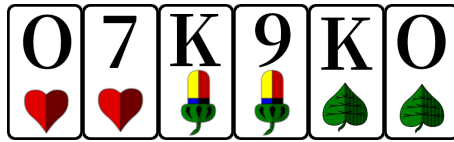
With our ace, Team Wenz Defense takes home 19 points. But on the downside, we gave up a top card– let's hope this doesn't bite us in the butt. The complete trick:

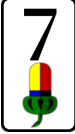
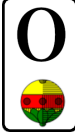
LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You
			

Third Trick

Partner Robert leads and gives it a try with the bell ace (after all, the player is wedged in the middle). Our hand:

Thinking it may be trumped, we hold back putting in points and put in a low heart. But player Lukas dumps an acorn, gifting us the trick. Matze must be out of butter...



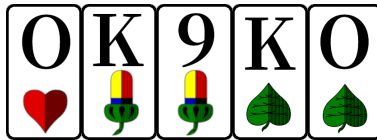
RightyRobert	You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze
			

Trump-or-dump situations are always unpleasant for the player.

Fourth Trick

Robert leads again, this time with a 7 of leaves. It's a shame he couldn't lead with a bell again to keep on the pressure. Playing unpleasant suits again can be a real wrench in a Wenz player's gears.

But a leaf was led. We're a bit afraid the ace is with the player, so we play the lower of our two leaves, the over. Our hand:

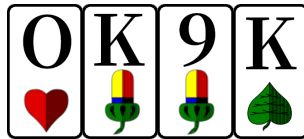


Our hunch proves right, and player Lukas takes it with his ace:

RightyRobert	You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze
			

Fifth Trick

Lukas' next card is the new top leaf, the 10. I wonder if he has that last under, and that's why he's so confidently leading his 10. In line with this hunch, the 10 takes it, but the defense largely stays away²⁵! Our hand:



And the trick:

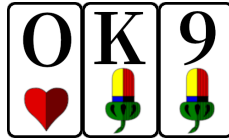
LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You
			

Sixth Trick

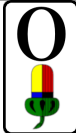
Lukas is succeeding at retaining the control with high cards. If we can't stop him soon, this could go very sour. We have

²⁵Atta way, Wenz defense!

three more cards (remember, one of the four unders is still in the game):



Lukas leads yet another high card:

LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You
			

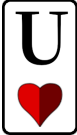
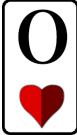
That other under must be with Lukas, everything's going through. Only two tricks are left– what's his other card (and our final hope)?

Seventh Trick

Left in our hand are:



Player Lukas again leads, and it's that last under that hits the table:

LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You
			

Eighth Trick

Our last card is the king of acorns. Will it do us any good?
The final cards drop, Lukas first:

LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You
			

It's an acorn, and the king beats the 8. We take home the final points of the game! Nonetheless, this late victory is not enough to turn the tables overall. We lose schneider-free with 51, but we put up a good fight.

Lessons Learned

- **Save your butter and wait for an opportunity.**
 - Sometimes there's a hole in the player's strategy. Depending on the distribution and whether defenders are empty, you can make her pay dearly for it, and win the solo in a few fat tricks.
- **Sometimes you have to gamble with your butter.**

- To make a tough game winnable, or even just to get out of schneider, risk can be a necessary element.
 - Betting on a missing trump can be dangerous, but sometimes a leap of faith is your only window of opportunity, and you have to hope your team has that high card.
- **Keep an eye on who's trumpless.**
 - Identifying early on whether any trumps are on your side can help you judge whether to butter or stay away.
 - If high-point suits are won repeatedly by the player, this can be another sign she has the rest of the trumps and, thus, nothing to worry about.

O4

RAMSCH

Ramsch is a game you don't want to play with a strong hand. So the first rule of Ramsch is: don't let it come to a Ramsch if you could have played!

The second rule of Ramsch is: don't get too worked up about it. It's usually a cheap game where you can't do much damage. So if you have questionable cards, do, by all means, pass, and hope the rest do, too. You'll probably win some chump change.

Counting Trumps

Counting the 14 trumps¹ is beneficial in a Ramsch, but not as necessary as in a regular game.

¹Ramsch uses the same trumps as a partner game.

If, however, you have a lot of trumps– or high trumps– it’s important to know which are left, and when you can rest assured your high trump or trump butter will be overtrumped.

Getting Empty

Being able to butter off your high cards to an ungrateful opponent is very important in Ramsch. The sooner you’re empty in a suit, the sooner you can butter your ace or ten away on a card of that suit– regardless how high or low.

Low on trump, low on aces and empty in at least one suit– that’s a great way to start a Ramsch.

Getting high trumps out cheaply

A hand with high trumps is dangerous in Ramsch. But while, generally, you want to avoid tricks at all cost, if you have a guaranteed trick taker like the over of acorns, you need to get him out cheaply. Don’t wait until trump is led, it’s your final trump, and you go home with a bucket of butter...

Instead, take a trick with the over when you’re in fourth position. You’ll know exactly how many points you’re getting, and sometimes you can get rid of that trump more cheaply than you would have by waiting.

Another tip for getting rid of high trumps is, as soon as a higher trump hits the table, to put in that high trump, thus eliminating it from the game at no cost to you.

Durchmarsch

If all else fails, and you already see a thick stack of tricks in front of you, a method of last resort can be the Durchmarsch: collect 91 points, and you win the Ramsch for the value of a solo!

This will require either a very strong hand (with which you probably shouldn't have Ramsched in the first place) or the element of surprise! Durchmarsch is particularly difficult if you're missing the top overs, and the others get wind of your strategy. They'll quickly take one for the team² rather than see you reach your 91 points.

Virgins

In Ramsch, anyone trickless at the end of the game is called a virgin³, and for each virgin, the value of that player's winnings (alternatively, the value of the whole round) is doubled. This is your goal. If you succeed, you're entitled to throw all humility to the wind, and wave your empty hands and fingers in the air⁴ in triumph.

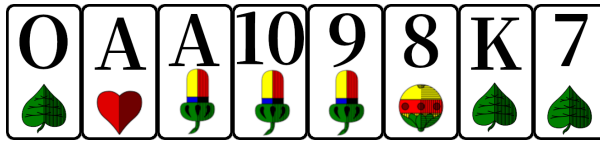
A Ramsch Run-Through

You know the basics, let's give it a try. You're second, and the whole table has passed. It's Ramsch time, here's your hand:

²Sacrifice themselves.

³German "Jungfrau".

⁴Think jazz hands.



First Trick

RightyRobert leads first, and starts low with the bottom bell.

RightyRobert	You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze

Matze takes it, looks like he couldn't stay away.

Second Trick

Matze leads with a low leaf. Our hand:

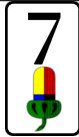


We decide to play it safe and put in the 7 of leaves. You never know when even a king can take the trick and expose you to butter!

MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You	LeftyLukas
			

Third Trick

Now you're last, and Lukas leads with the bottom acorn:

LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You
			...

Oh, dear. Our hand:



We play the lowest and cheapest acorn we have, but it's still too high. Regrettably, we collect some butter from empty Robert:

LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You
			

Fourth Trick

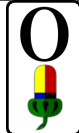
We look at our cards, and think about which suits still have their trick takers out:



Darn it, we're in a bit of a pickle⁵. Leaves are a no-go, given the ace and the 10 are gone, and our king is high. That could be a butter magnet, too, since leaves already was played.

It would also be no good to lead again after winning, it would just put us into the same situation all over again with our high acorns. So shall we take a risk?

We play our ace of trump, and hope someone is forced to put at least an under on top:

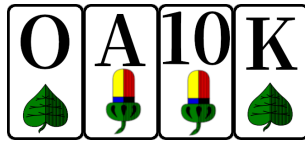
You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert
			

Phew! We're safe, and Robert leads in the fifth trick.

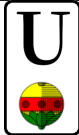
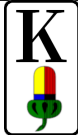
Fifth Trick

Here's our hand:

⁵Not a sweet situation.



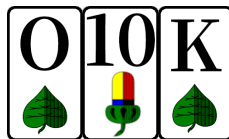
Robert leads one of the last bells, the 9 (we're all out of jingles⁶):

RightyRobert	You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze
			

We butter it up, and Lukas takes it away with an under. He must have a lot of trump left. Matze seemingly has run out of butter.

Sixth Trick

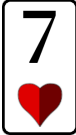
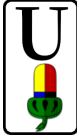
As Lukas leads, we check out our cards:



Lukas plays the lowest trump, the 7.

We have no choice, given our single remaining trump, the over of leaves. But it's a cheap-enough trick at seven points:

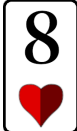
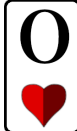
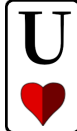
⁶"Jingle bells..."

LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You
			

Seventh Trick

The 10 of acorns and the king of leaves are both the top of their suits, but– we counted the trumps all along, of course, and know there are exactly five trumps left among the opponents. With two cards in each hand, trump has to fall in each of the last two tricks!

That's great news, and means we can play either of our cards without worry. We put in the 10 of acorns:

You	LeftyLukas	MiddleMatze	RightyRobert
			

Eighth Trick

It's Matze's trick, and he leads with the over of bells. Ouch for him, that's the top of the top:

Matze's over takes the last trick and bags two kings and an ace, to boot. Everyone counts his score, and Matze ends "on top" with 51 points! Lukas 27, Robert 24, and you're best with 18. That makes +10 points each for the winners, all paid by generous Matze (-30).

MiddleMatze	RightyRobert	You	LeftyLukas
			

Lessons Learned

- **Leading a trump ace is a gamble.**
 - It was a big risk, but with the alternative of an all-but-guaranteed buttery trick thanks to our high card.
 - Dangerous uncertainty is preferable to certain danger...
- **Ramsch is all about butter.**
 - The faster you're empty in suits, the faster your liabilities⁷ become your assets.
- **Claiming a cheap trick with a high trump can save you a whole trick later.**
 - If you can get rid of a high trump cheaply, or if you can waste that trump when you'd have to take the trick anyway, you may avoid winning more trump tricks later.

⁷High suit cards.

05

ENGLISH SCHAFKOPF GLOSSARY

- Ace game
 - A partner game.
- Acorns
 - The highest-ranked suit among overs and unders. Equivalent to clubs.
- Beim Wenz spielt man Ässe oder hält die Fresse
 - In a Wenz you play aces, or you shut your pie-hole. Refers to the fact you need to control the suits to some degree to play a Wenz.

- Bells
 - The lowest-ranked suit among overs and unders. Equivalent to diamonds.
- Blocked
 - Not able to call a partner, because you either have all the aces, or are empty in the suit of the ace to be called.
- Butter
 - High-value cards (usually 10s or aces) you put into your team's tricks when you expect or know your team will take it with another card.
- Butter in
 - To put high-value cards in your partner's trick.
- Butter-or-bite situation
 - Put in butter or take the trick.
 - Situation in which the opponent(s) currently own the trick, and you should choose one of two approaches: 1) taking it over with trump and 2) buttering in points in the hopes a partner will take it. Taking the third option and dumping a low-pointer can be a game breaker in these cases.
- Butter trumps

- The ace and 10 of trump.
- Butterless suit
 - A suit in which the ace and 10 are gone, often led by solo defenders sandwiching a player in the middle, in order to induce a trump-or-dump dilemma.
- Caller
 - The player who called the ace.
- Champion's trick
 - A trick with 40 or more points.
- Contra
 - Announcement doubling the game value that can be called by the defense until that player's first card has been played.
- Der Dumme sucht
 - The dumb one searches. Said of an ace caller who searches for the called ace himself instead of leading trump.
- Double trouble
 - A comical rhyming phrase said for fun when doubling.
- Duck

- To intentionally not take a trick, putting in a card below the highest.
- The duck is fat in the butt
 - Hinten ist die Ente fett
 - Often the highest-point cards are retained until the end of the game.
- Dump (trash)
 - To strategically get rid of cards.
- Dump empties
 - To strategically get rid of 0-point cards
- Durchmarsch
 - In Ramsch, turning the tables to win by reaching 90 points.
- Empties
 - 7s, 8s, 9s; cards worth no points.
- Empty
 - Having no cards in a given suit (and thus being able to trump).
- Expensive trick
 - A trick with lots of points that went to the opponent(s).

- Extract trumps
 - To force opponents to play trumps (best when you have the trump majority on your side).
- Fat trick
 - A trick with 20 or more points.
- First
 - The player left of the dealer who bids first or plays the first card.
- Follow suit
 - To play a card of the suit that was led (required when possible).
- Forehand
 - The person left of the dealer, who bids and plays first.
- Free
 - Having no cards in a given suit (and thus being able to trump).
- Freestanding
 - Said of a card that is the only representative of its respective suit; a singleton.
- Garden salad

- A hand with all the suits, especially when they are well mixed.
- Gone through
 - Referring to a suit that has already been led in a trick.
- Grass
 - Another word for the suit leaves.
- Grass ass
 - A funny way to refer to the leaf ace.
- Green
 - Another word for the suit leaves.
- Guarantee a trick
 - To put the top trump into a trick.
- Heartless
 - A player without any hearts.
- High card
 - The highest remaining card of a given suit.
- Hundsgefickte
 - Risqué description of the ace of bells, which depicts a pig with a dog atop its back.

- In the hole
 - Schneider (win level reached when defenders are under 30 points, players under 31).
- Last
 - The final person to bid or play a card.
- Lead
 - To play the first card of the trick or game.
- Leaves
 - The second-highest ranked suit among overs and unders. Equivalent to spades.
- Middlehand
 - Person in second or third position.
- Oma hand
 - A hand so good even your granny would win it.
- Out of the hole
 - Schneider-free
- Outbid
 - To bid a higher-value game than the original bidder.
- Own a trick

- To have played the current high card of the unfinished trick on the table.
- Pig
 - English translation of Sau, the Bavarian term for ace.
- Pull trumps
 - To force opponents to play trumps (best when you have the trump majority on your side).
- Re(contra)
 - Reaction of the player team to the announcement of contra, doubling game value once again.
- Rearhand
 - Person last to play.
- Red
 - Another name for the hearts.
- Run away
 - To lead with another card of the called suit (when you have four of the called suit as the partner).
- Sandwich
 - An unpleasant position for a solo player, having a defender on either side (player is second or third).

- Useful for forcing a trump-or-dump dilemma on the solo player.
- Schmier
 - Another word for butter (high point-value cards)
- Schneider
 - Win level reached when defenders are under 30 points, players under 31.
- Schneider-free
 - The state of the given team being better than schneider.
- Schwarz
 - Win level reached by one side having made zero tricks (not points, tricks).
- Search
 - To look for the called ace by playing any card of its suit. Typically done by a defender.
- Secure a trick
 - To put the top trump into a trick.
- Shoot blanks
 - To take a trick, but win little to no points.
- Singleton

- Your sole card of a given suit. Often good for dumping so as to become empty in that suit.
- Solo game
 - A suit solo, Wenz or Geier
- Solo pot
 - A jackpot paid into when everyone passes and hands are redealt (instead of Ramsch). The next solo player wins the pot, or must double it, if lost (regular payouts still apply on top).
- Stick the pig
 - As a defender, to trump the called ace when it is searched for.
- Take out trumps
 - To force opponents to play trumps (best when you have the trump majority on your side).
- Top card
 - The highest remaining card of a given suit.
- Top trump
 - Over of acorns or whatever the highest remaining trump may be.
- Trump butter
 - The ace and 10 of trump.

- Trump-or-dump dilemma
 - A unpleasant situation for a solo player in the middle, in which she must decide whether to take over a trick with trump or give it away by dumping a card, risking enemy butter (especially when opponents are empty).
 - One way to do this is to lead a butterless suit as a defender in front of a sandwiched player.
- Virgin
 - In Ramsch, any player who collected zero tricks.
- With an under, you won't go under
 - Mit dem Unter gehst du nicht unter
 - Similar to the argument "when in doubt, play an under". The recommendation highlights the fact the under is still above the butter trumps and can force high trumps into play.

06

MORE GAMES WITH BAVARIAN CARDS

06.1 66

This zesty two-player is a great way to spend time with a friend in your local bar or living room.

66 can be played with a 20-card deck, using only the 10s through aces. This version of the game is also known as "Schnapsen", and is very popular in Austria. You can play with a German deck, but an ordinary pack of cards will work just as well.



Figure O6.1: A hand of 66

Setup

- At the start of the game, each player is dealt five cards.
- An additional card is uncovered and placed under the deck face-up perpendicularly. This is the trump suit.
- The game begins by the player who didn't deal playing a card.

Gameplay

The aim of 66 is to make tricks and marriages to accumulate 66 points before your opponent. You have to remember your points, but can always look at your most recent trick.

Making tricks

To make a trick, the opponent must play a higher card of the same suit or a trump card.

- You are not required to follow suit or to make a trick
 - You have the option to play a card of the wrong suit or trump.
- The player who makes the trick plays the next card.
- After each trick, each player draws another card (until the deck runs out). The trick-taker draws first, up to and including the final, face-up card.
- **Once the deck runs out, you must follow suit and must make the trick if possible.**

Card by Trick Rank	Points
Ace	11
10	10
King	4
Over	3
Under	2

Marriages

Marriages consist of an king and over (or king and queen, go figure) of the same suit. You can only announce a marriage if it's your turn to begin the trick, and you are required to play one of the two cards after announcing and showing them both.

Marriages are worth the following points:

- 40 points for a marriage in trump
- 20 points for each non-trump marriage

Closing the deck

You can pressure your opponent by closing the deck (on your turn). As soon as the deck is closed or runs out, players are required to make a trick or follow suit if possible.

If the deck was closed, the closing player must win (by reaching 66)! If they don't, the opponent wins at least two match points.

Once the deck has been closed, the defending player does not get points for any tricks or marriages they may make from that time until the end of the round.

Stealing the trump

If you have the lowest trump card (under of trump), you can exchange it for the trump under the deck when it's your turn. This can be very beneficial if that's a good card (eventually, that card will be drawn otherwise).

End of Game

If you think you have reached 66 points, just say "66" when it's your turn, ending the round. But watch out– if you don't actually have 66, you lose!

- Even if both players actually have 66, the first one to call it wins.

- Otherwise the game ends when all the cards have been played.
 - If no one has called 66 or closed by this point, the last trick wins!

Scoring

Situation	Points
Called 66 or closed deck and opponent has 33 or more	1
Called 66 or closed deck and opponent has less than 33	2
Called 66 or closed deck and opponent made no tricks	3
Erroneously called 66 or lost after closing and opponent had 33 or more	2
Erroneously called 66 or lost after closing and opponent had no tricks	3
Neither player called 66 or closed deck (winner of final trick wins)	1

Seven match points wins! Remember that once the deck is closed, the defender's card points are frozen, regardless of what future tricks or marriages she may make.

Variants

Viewing your tricks

Some circles reduce the memory aspect by allowing you to view your own tricks at any time, as well as the last of the

opponent's tricks.

Playing with the 9s

You can also play 66 with 24 cards (including the 9s). In this case, the 9s are worth 0 points, and each player is initially dealt six cards instead of five. All else remains the same.



Figure 06.2: Offenbacher 66 Meister, Edvin (right)

Recommended Apps

- schnopsen.com
 - The most popular Schnapsen/66 app. This one lets you switch between various card faces and usually works very well (with ads).

- Great for playing online.
- Schnapsen Offline (Android)
 - Nice offline implementation with pretty German-suited cards.
 - Also nice is that you can opt to hide or show your points.
- 66 Offline (Android)
 - Nice implementation of 66 with the 9s and six-card hands.
 - You can choose to show your points or not.
 - Only French-suited (JQK) cards are possible.

06.2 Schnauz

Win by not losing! In this dynamic party game, keep your lives to stay afloat.

Schnauz is played with a 32-card deck, using only the 7s through aces.

- The game is played best with 3-7 players.
- It's also known as 31, Schwimmen, Blitz, Scat, Knock-Knock...

Setup

At the start of the game, each player is given three lives (matchsticks, coins, etc.), and each player is dealt three cards.



Figure 06.3: Lives are traditionally tracked with matchsticks.

- The dealer inspects her cards first, and has the option to keep them or put them in the center and take three new cards.
 - If the dealer keeps her cards, three additional cards from the deck are placed in the center face-up.

The player to the left of the dealer is first to play.

Gameplay

The aim of Schnauz is to gather three cards of the same suit for the highest score.

- Aces are worth 11, face cards 10, and all other cards are worth their number value.
- Each turn, players may exchange **one or all cards, but not two**.

- The round ends in one of three ways:
 - A player reaches 31 points ("Schnauz!")
 - A player has three aces ("fire!")
 - A player closes the round
 - * Closing is denoted by knocking and is only possible after the first round.
 - * If you choose to close, you may not exchange cards, and the game ends after every other player has one more chance to play.

End of Game

The player(s) with the lowest score loses one life. Once all a player's lives are gone, she is "swimming" on one final life, after which she loses, and is out.

Additional Important Rules

- If a player gets three aces, the game is immediately over, and every other player loses one life: "fire!"
- Three-of-a-kind is worth exactly 30.5 points. You'll never lose with this hand.
- You can always pass instead of exchanging cards or closing.
- If everyone passes on a set of cards, three new cards are dealt from the deck. This is most relevant when only two or three players are left.

Strategy Tips

- The earlier you can get a high score, the earlier you can "knock" to jump the gun on opponents that haven't had time to collect points.
- Make sure you don't accidentally create a good hand on the table by exchanging cards.
 - Remember, the next player can take all three cards!

App Recommendation

There is a great Android/iOS app that lets you play with different types of cards (German suits, regular suits):

- 31 App from Donkeycat

06.3 Three-Player Schafkopf

It is possible to play a version of Schafkopf with three players with ten cards each and a blind of two cards.

- Deal each player three, two to the middle, each player four, then each player three.
- Partner games are not possible: only Geier, Wenz or Solo.
- The winner of the bid gets to exchange two cards from her hand with the two in the middle.
- The trumps are the same as in four-person Schafkopf.

Bidding with Three

The forehand (player left of the dealer) begins bidding by saying: "I would play".

- Geier, Wenz and Solo are all equally ranked.
- To outbid the person before you, you must offer to win with more points (in increments of five):
 - Example:
 - * Forehand: I would play!
 - * Middlehand: would you play 65?
 - * Forehand: yes, I would play 65.
 - * Middlehand: how about 70?
 - * Forehand: no, I pass.
 - * Rearhand: I pass.
 - The bidwinner must make at least this number to win. In this case, the middlehand wins it for 70 points (if she gets 69, she loses).
 - Another, less likely, example:
 - * Forehand: I would play!
 - * Middlehand: would you play 65?
 - * Forehand: yes, I would play 65.
 - * Middlehand: how about 70?
 - * Forehand: no, I pass.
 - * Rearhand: can you do 75?
 - * Middlehand: no, I pass.

- In this case, the forehand was outbid by the middlehand, who again was outbid by the rearhand, who now must score 75 points to win.

If everyone passes, a Ramsch can be played, leaving the blind untouched on the table. Alternatively, the cards can be redealt, each player paying a small amount into the jackpot for the next winner to rake in.

Exchanging

The bidwinner has the option to exchange cards from the blind before declaring the game she will play.

- The exchanged cards are not revealed to the others, and they count toward her tricks.
 - This gives a chance to become empty in one or more suits, or to already rack up points!
- "Hand": if you win the bid and believe you don't need to exchange to win, play Hand!
 - Hand games are worth double.
 - The cards from the blind still count as your points.

Scoring

As in regular Schafkopf, defenders are schneider-free with 30 points, and schwarz with zero tricks.

- A won game can be scored at 40 points, with each loser paying this price to the winner, or the single loser to the two winners.

- Schneider gives you 10 points more, schwarz yet another ten, just as in the four-person game.
- "Hand" (without exchanging) doubles the value of the game.
- Tout (announcing you'll take all the tricks) doubles the value of the game, as in regular Schafkopf.
- If you lose any trick, you lose.

06.4 Lake Constance Jass

Win the bid to choose the trump, make tricks, but don't fall in the sack! This two-player bidding game from the Lake Constance region of Germany, Austria and Switzerland is also known as "Bodenseejaß".



Figure 06.4: Lake Constance Jass with a Salzburger deck

Setup

With a 36 card deck (6-A), shuffle and deal each player three cards face down twice, so that each player has a row of six face-down cards in front of them. Then deal cards face-up on top of them, again 2x3. These are your table cards. Deal another 2x3 cards per player for your hands.

Object of the Game

The aim of the game is to bid wisely and either reach your bid, or keep your opponent from reaching hers. Win five tallies and you are the victor.

Bidding

The game starts by players inspecting their hands and estimating how many points they will be able to make. There are 157 total points in the game, so it makes sense to start bidding around 70. You must bid in increments of five. The non-dealer begins the bidding and the winner of the bid gets to choose the trump and play first.

This can be very decisive because the high bidder will attempt to choose the trump in which she has a "Bur" or "Nell" (see scoring below).

Possible Games

Usually, the bid winner chooses a suit to become trump (trump game), and all nine cards of that suit become the trumps for the game.

However, if you don't have lots of one suit, but have lots of high cards or low cards, you can consider playing without trumps! In "Bock" or "Gais", there are no trumps, and the eights are worth eight points to compensate the missing Bur and Nell. Bock is top-down: the usual ranking of cards applies, and aces are high. But in Gais, it's an upside-down game, and the sixes have the highest rank with the aces at the bottom. Watch out though, the point values per card remain the same!

Cards by Trick Rank	Point Value
Under of Trump ("Bur")	20
Nine of Trump ("Nell")	14
Ace of Trump	11
King of Trump	4
Over of Trump	3
Ten of Trump	10
Eight of Trump	0
Seven of Trump	0
Six of Trump	0
Ace of Other Suit	11 (x3)
King of Other Suit	4 (x3)
Over of Other Suit	3 (x3)
Under of Other Suit	2 (x3)
Ten of Other Suit	10 (x3)
Nine of Other Suit	0 (x3)
Eight of Other Suit	0 (x3)
Seven of Other Suit	0 (x3)
Six of Other Suit	0 (x3)
<i>Making the last trick</i>	5
SUM	157

Bock (Top-Down)

Cards by Trick Rank	Point Value
Ace	11 (x4)
King	4 (x4)
Over	3 (x4)
Under	2 (x4)
Ten	10 (x4)
Nine	0 (x4)
Eight	8 (x4)
Seven	0 (x4)
Six	0 (x4)
<i>Making the last trick</i>	5
SUM	157

Gais (Bottom-Up)

Cards by Trick Rank	Point Value
Six	0 (x4)
Seven	0 (x4)
Eight	8 (x4)
Nine	0 (x4)
Ten	10 (x4)
Under	2 (x4)
Over	3 (x4)
King	4 (x4)
Ace	11 (x4)
<i>Making the last trick</i>	5
SUM	157

Making Tricks

In Jass, you win a trick by playing the highest-ranked card of the led suit. If you win the trick, you get to start the next trick. As in other games, any trump card can beat even the best card of the led suit.

In Lake Constance Jass, you can always choose to play a card from your hand or from the table. Once the trick is won, turn over any freshly revealed table cards.

Following Suit

Following suit is a bit unusual in Jass: when an opponent starts the trick and you have a card of that suit (whether in your hand or on the table) you must play a card of that suit or a trump. If you don't have a card of the led suit, you may play any card (and you are not required to trump). A led trump must always be followed with trump.

One exception: **you don't have to follow suit with the Bur** (but you do with the Nell).

You are not required to make a trick, and can intentionally lose a trick, as long as you follow suit as specified above.

Scorekeeping

If the winner of the bid reaches the score bid, she writes one tally. If she misses it, the opponent writes one tally. If either player makes less than 21 points, they are "in the sack". This means the winner writes a tally as usual, but the loser writes a "o", which is equivalent to a negative tally. To get "out of

the sack", the player has to win another round, crossing through the o with a line:

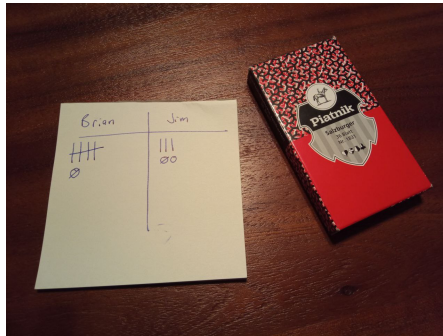


Figure 06.5: Jim needs to get out of the sack before he can make another tally.

End of Game

The round is over when one player has made five tallies.

06.5 Solitaire

It's also possible to play a version of solitaire with Bavarian cards. You can play with all 36 cards (6-A). To start, take the four aces out of the deck, and place them in the middle of the table.

The rest of the deck is the draw pile, and the aim of the game is to stack the cards on the aces in ascending order. After the ace comes the 6, comes the 7, etc. The card order is "normal": after the 9 comes the 10, comes the under, comes the over, comes the king.



Figure 06.6: Solitaire and coffee in Munich

If you can't put a card on an ace stack, you have to put it in one of the four corners. You can play cards from those four corners at any time, but only the top card of the stack (the rest are blocked).

Once you've gone through the deck once, you have one more chance: combine the four corner stacks without shuffling, and turn them over to use as a new draw pile. Let's hope this time it works!

You win the game if you end up with four complete stacks of ace through king.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

This little book would not have been possible without the influence, inspiration and support of the following people and organizations:

- My wife, Eva
 - For unwavering support in even my most unusual undertakings.
- Card Table Offenbach
 - For the international cameraderie and many a night of Belgian beer.
- Schafkopfverein Royal Frankfurt e.V.
 - For patiently showing me the ropes and being a treasure trove of Schafkopf wisdom.
- Schafkopfrunde Alzenau

- For my first game in native Schafkopf territory and for demonstrating the appeal of playing for keepsies.
- Traditional Card Games Discord Server
 - For opening my eyes to Europe's the colorful palette of cards in acorn, leaf, bell and beyond.
- Schafkopf author, Stefan Dillig
 - For a very friendly correspondence, full of encouragement and support over several months.
- Card-game researcher and author of www.pagat.com, John McLeod
 - For helpful tips and review of the first edition.
- Resident statistician of SVR-Frankfurt, Peter Schmenkel
 - For motivating conversations in Pilsstube Royal and giving me a glimpse of the the high peaks that can be scaled in search of Schafkopf perfection.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR



Brian Junker-Latocha, born 1988 in Indiana, USA and in Germany since 2008, lives in Offenbach am Main with his wonderful wife and three cats. When he's not playing Schafkopf with his friends, you can find him brainstorming on whiteboards in the IT world or playing foot-tapping folk tunes on the guitar.